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Black nomads of the Sahara

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3. Family obligations.

Among the Toubou, the household is the basic unit: a husband, a wife, their children, joined together in the family tent. This is the affective family, the coherent absolute, united both by sentiment and material interests. Here the man finds his strongest attachments. He has towards his wife and children duties which demand fulfillment and rights which he endeavors to exercise.

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He has towards them first of all a duty of protection. In the dispersed state of Toubou society, in the material and moral isolation in which every tent exists, the head of the family is often the only bulwark between what belongs to him and outside dangers: it is here that his warrior role begins. He will not let any offense go by, any rough joke, any violence towards his own without avenging it. Let someone strike his wife or one of his children, that persons will be followed, attacked, wounded, sometimes killed.

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His second duty is to provide for the needs of his tent: to feed and clothe wife and children. For that he must tend his herd and make it prosper, buy grain and cloth outside. If necessity demands, he must go far away to steal animals, attack a caravan, pillage settlers.

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Finally, he must uphold his own reputation so that his wife and children are never put to shame through him. He will be obliged to be the donode man, the strong man, reputable in the handling of arms, bringing honor to his clan, undertaking vengeance incumbent upon him, ignoring danger and fatigue.

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If he is found wanting, he will see his wife turn from him and shame haunt his children. Though he is on the road, hundreds of kilometers from home, it is his tent that he will think of if there is an occasion to show his bravery by a dagger's blow or the throwing of the assegai.

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Despite the obligations he has towards his family and his feeling of responsibilities, the man finds himself extremely free. If he 291 leaves his tent it is to do man's work, and, once underway, he will follow his inspiration or his fancy. His travels may be prolonged for months, during which time his wife will not worry about knowing where he is or what he is doing.

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The rights of the head of the family depend, in fact, on the measure of control that he succeeds in establishing over his family. He commands or does not command depending on whether he knows or does not know when to assert himself. He may beat his wife and use this right, but he does not abuse it (except when she sometimes defends herself), for if he does, it will then be necessary for him to make some gift in order to return into her good graces.

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